

Professor Sandee Chamberlain
Kennesaw State University – Georgia | USA
Email – schamb37@kennesaw.edu

A cartoon illustration of a smiling fox character. The fox has orange fur, large orange ears, and wears round glasses. It is dressed in a blue short-sleeved shirt with yellow floral patterns and grey shorts. The fox is standing with its arms slightly out to the sides. The background is a solid light blue.

Let's begin -

- [illegible]

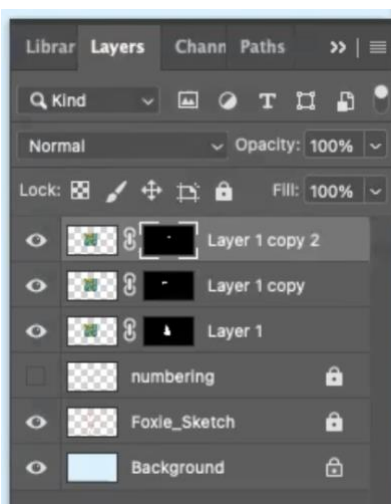


2. Once warmed up create a sketch of your character that you would like to create for use in a puppet rig animation. I chose to create a fox character

3. Then we will begin to break out different parts of the character to be animated – I like to number them to keep track of everything. Even in a simple character such as this we can have many layers to work with.



4. Next, we will be importing our different paper textures to use to create the parts of character.



5. Once you have chosen a texture to work with – use the **Lasso Tool** to create a selection around the part of the character you would like the texture to appear – the first one I did was the torso area of the shirt and sleeves. Click the **Mask Tool** button at the bottom of the **Layer Palette** – this will mask the texture to where you made the selection (be sure to have your texture layer selected before hitting the mask button – which looks like the white rectangle with the circle cut out of it).



6. Duplicate your texture files multiple times to use later in the file – also, once the masked layer looked the way I wanted – I duplicated that layer then selected both layers and **merged layers** together by hitting the hotkeys (**Command or**

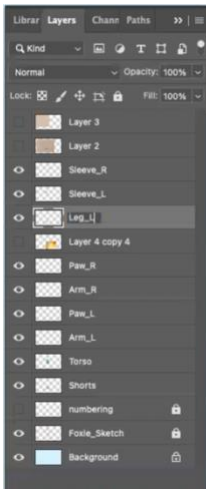
Control + E). I did this extra step to in effect solidify the mask into a non-masked layer that would be easy to import and work with in Toon Boom.



7. Continue to create textured mask for the rest of the parts of your character using the method suggested above.

8. Make sure to name all of your layers in Photoshop – as this will translate directly into Toon Boom Harmony. You can use any naming convention that is intuitive – for example – I use (Leg_L) for screen left leg.

9. Don't worry if your layers are not in the proper view order as we will correct this at the end and also it can be corrected in Toon Boom using the Node View.

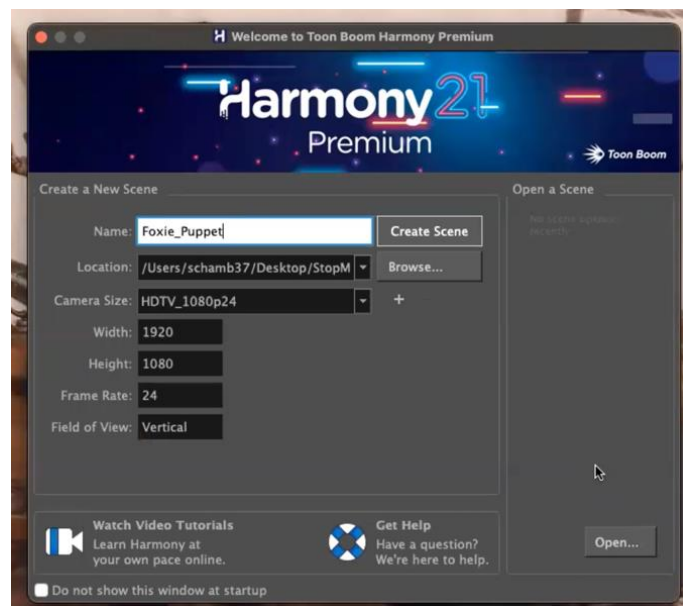


10. Finish up the rest of the character – I broke the tail into four parts for animation purposes.

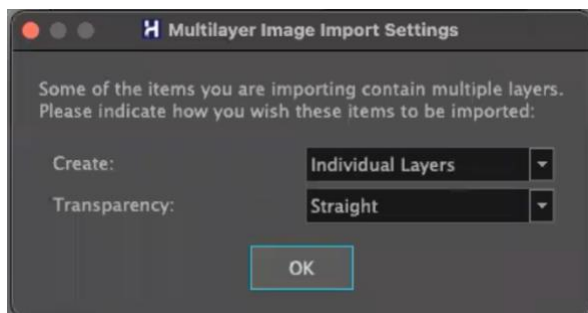
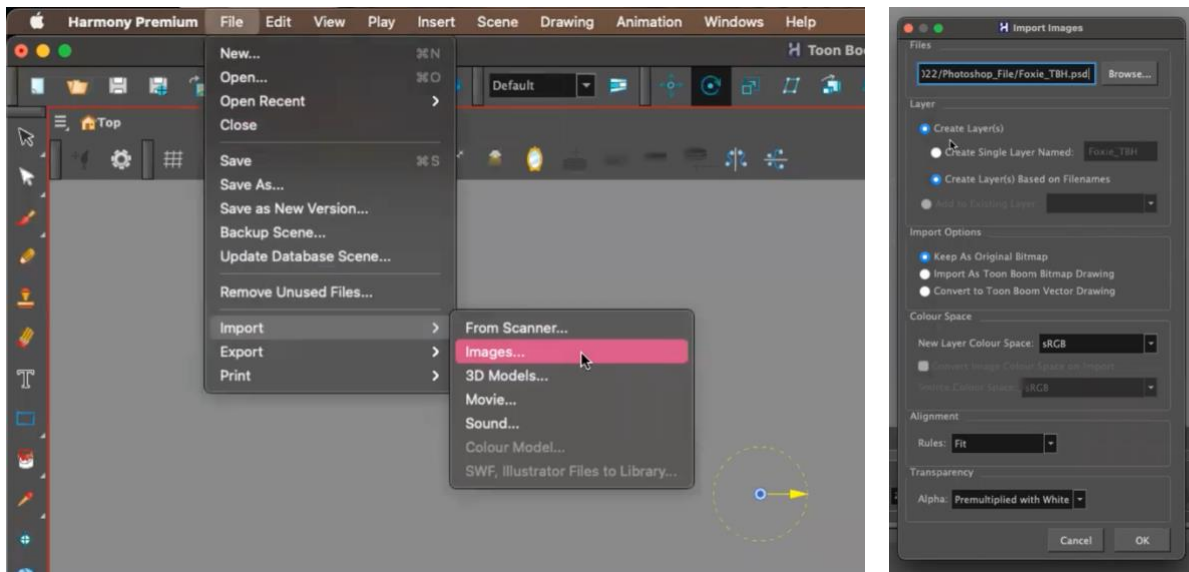


11. When I was done – I ended up fixing the foot right to match the color of the rest of the character better – but here you will see it is distinctively yellow.

12. The next step is to launch Toon Boom Harmony and set a destination folder by clicking the Browse button and giving your file a name.

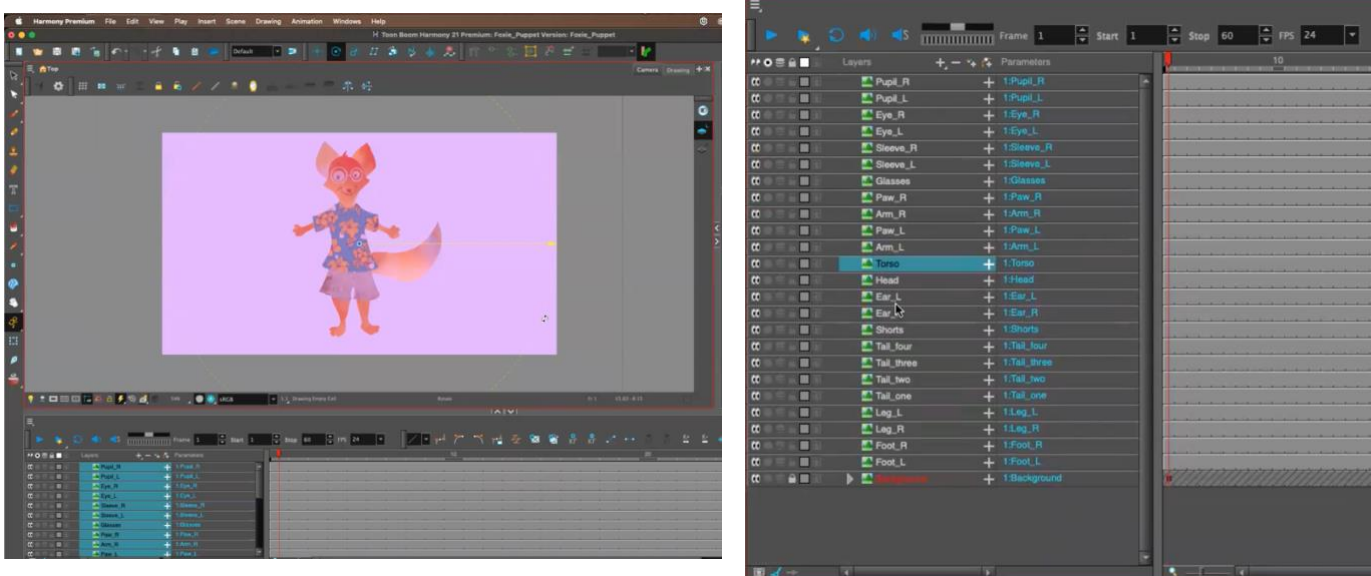


13. Let's import our image – **FILE>IMPORT>IMAGES** – a dialogue box will appear make sure to click the button next to **Creating Layer(s) – Create Layer(s) Based on File Names – Keep as Original Bitmap** then click **OK** - this should be the default options but just in case just match the images below:

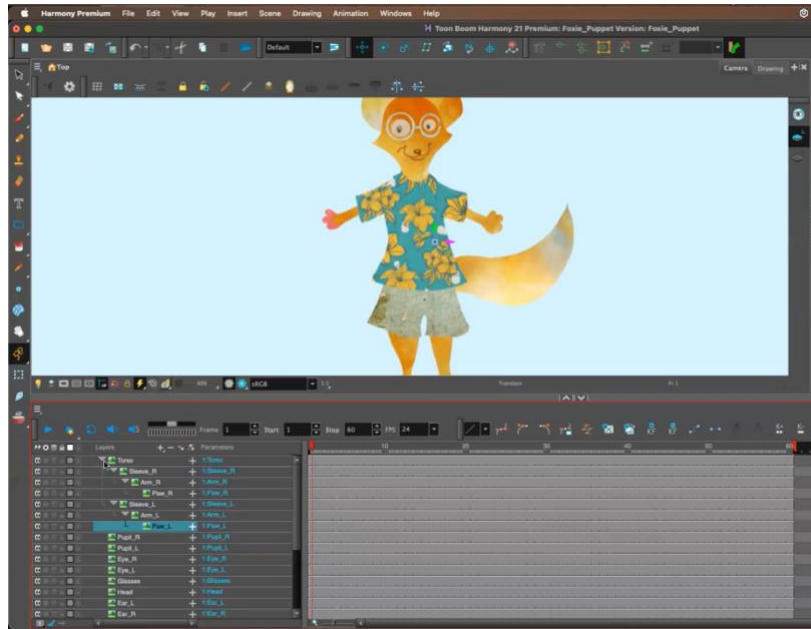


Also – these should be the default options on the next dialogue box to appear as well – if not match again with the image to the left.

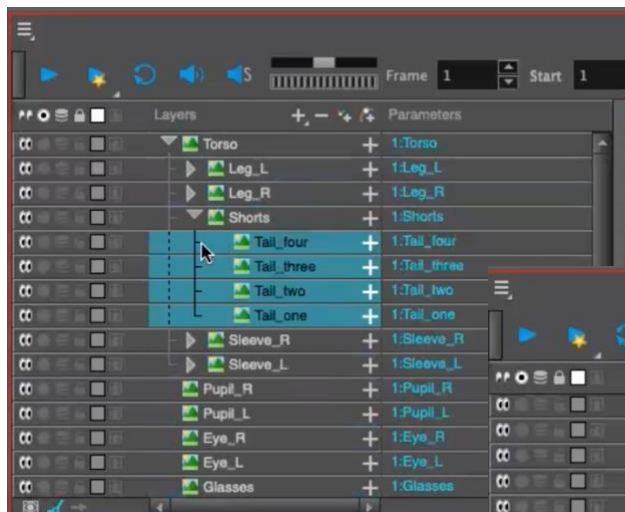
14. Your character from Photoshop will import and appear in the Stage area of the UI -all the layers should be named the same and will appear in the timeline layers area below the stage.



15. We will now begin to nest our layers so that individual parts of the character will follow each other. I begin with the Body - in this case the layer named **Torso** – I will drag this layer to the top in my timeline layers. Because eventually every layer / part of the character will connect into and follow the torso. Do this by dragging and dropping layers into the Torso layer, you will see a black line appear just the in inside of the name Torso then drop and you will see the layer is nested and Torso will now have a drop-down arrow and a light grey line that connects the layers.

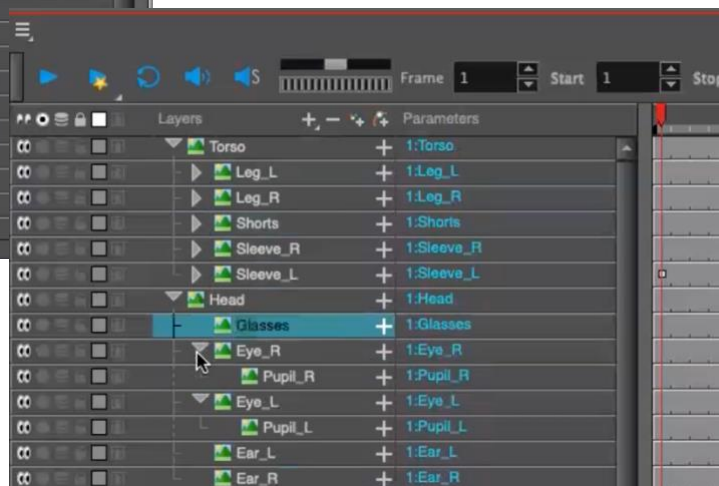


16. There will also be other layers that will need to follow each other for example – the Sleeve will follow the Torso and you can double and triple nest the Arms and Paws – just remember that everything will follow back up and move with which ever layers it is nested.

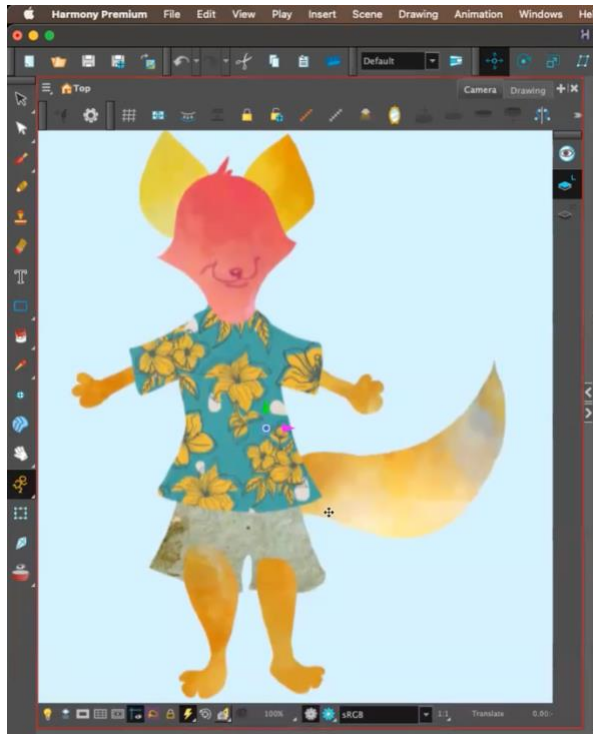


17. See to the left how all four **Tail** sections should follow the and be nested under the **Shorts** which is already nested under the **Torso**.

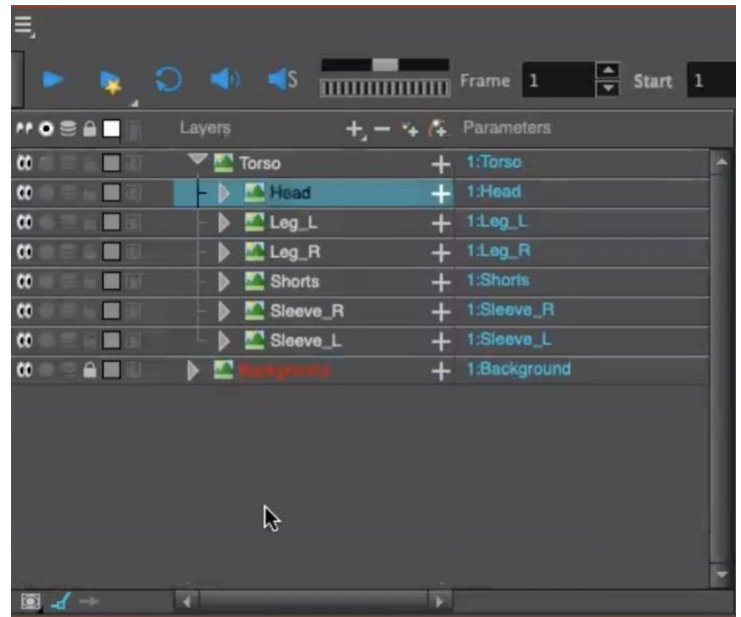
18. Continue this method with the **Head** – nest the **Eyes, Pupils, Ears, and Glasses**



19. The parts of your character will not be in correct visual space order when doing this process – again don't worry we are about to fix that in the **NODE VIEW**

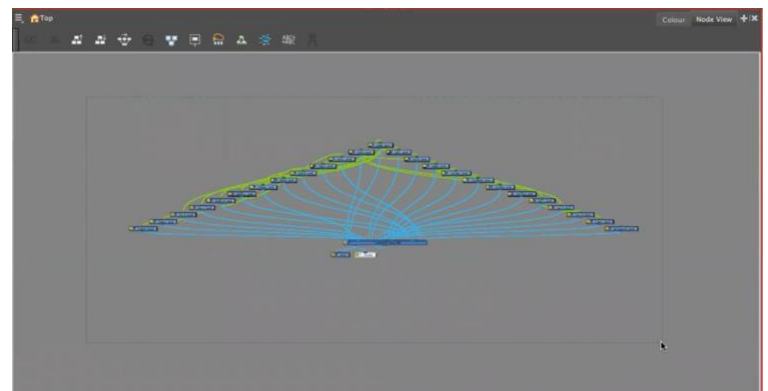
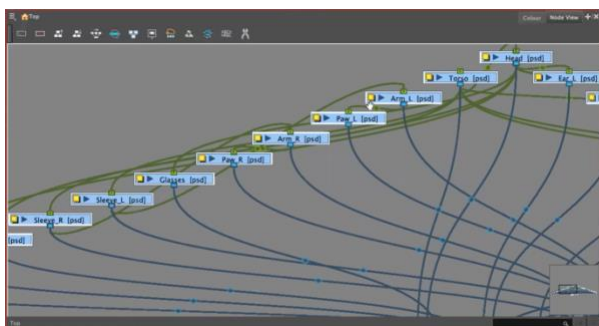


20. Once you collapse all of the nestled layers your timeline should look the image below.

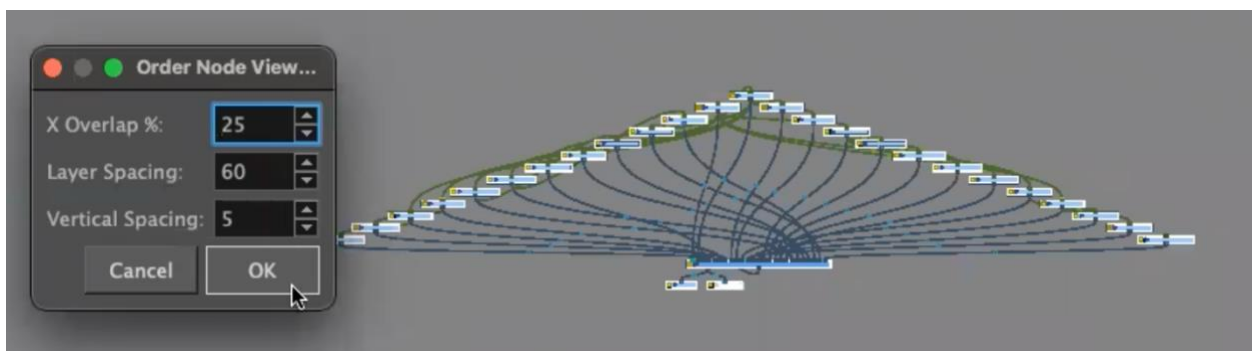
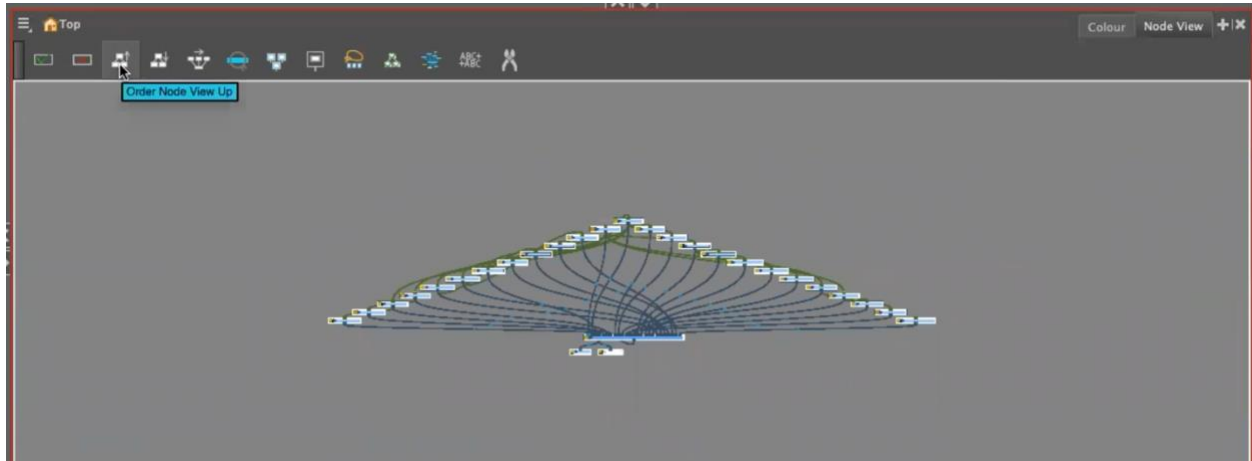


21. Let's work in the Node View (it's the tab right next to your color palette tab on the right hand side of the screen – this should be open by default if you don't see it go to **WINDOWS>RESTORE DEFAULT WORKSPACE**

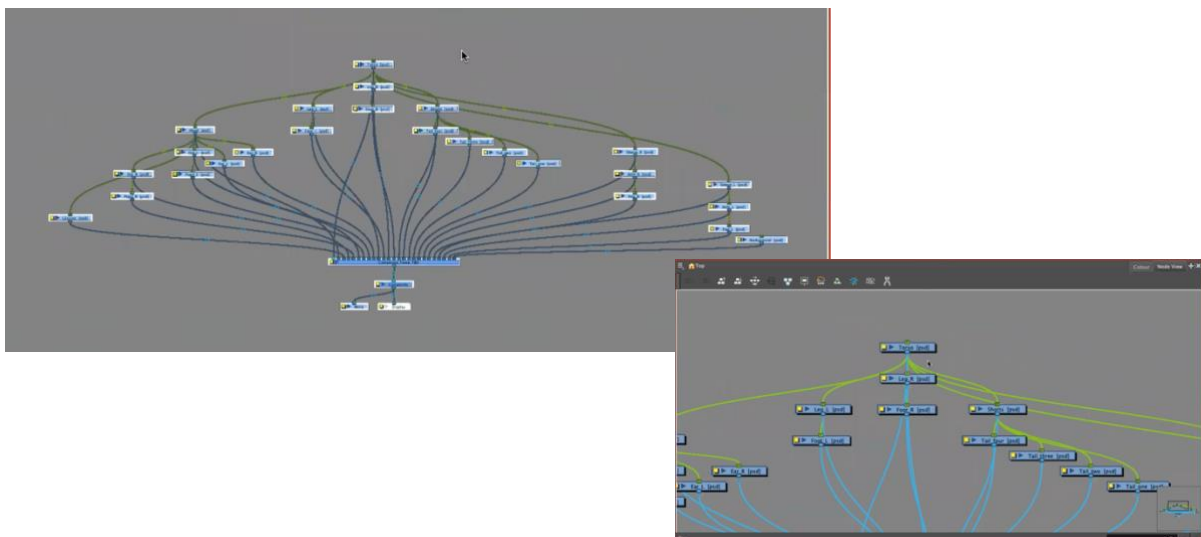
This might look like a tangled mess at first but we will organize it easily – you will have a Composite Node (this is the long one at the bottom – which is essentially your stage if you disconnect a layer from the composite it will disappear from the stage view but will still exist in the file – just hook the line back to the composite node and your image will reappear). Each **Drawing/Image** layer in your timeline will have a corresponding node in the Node View – which should match your original naming convention.



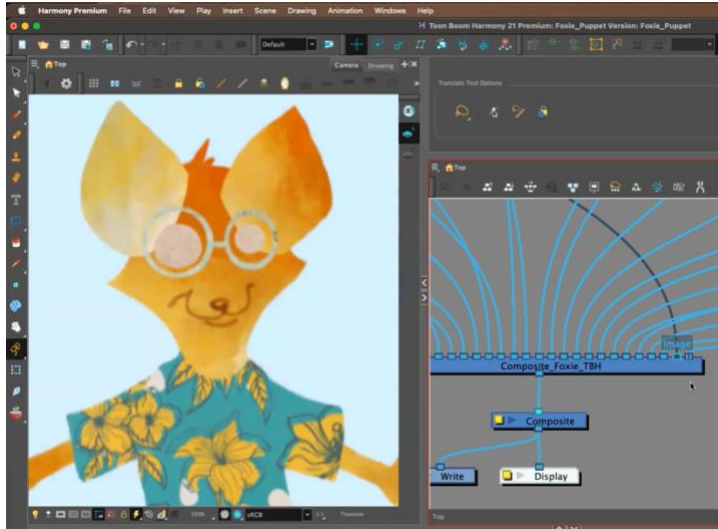
22. Now let's clean up our nodes – start by using your cursor to drag a box around all of the nodes in the Node View. Then in the upper left of that palette click the **Order Node View Up** button – this will give you a dialogue box with a default set of values just leave them alone and click **OK**.



Now everything looks a bit tidier, and we can clearly see the connections – blue lines represent the Drawing/Image Nodes connecting to the Composite – green lines represent those nested connections between the layers in the timeline.

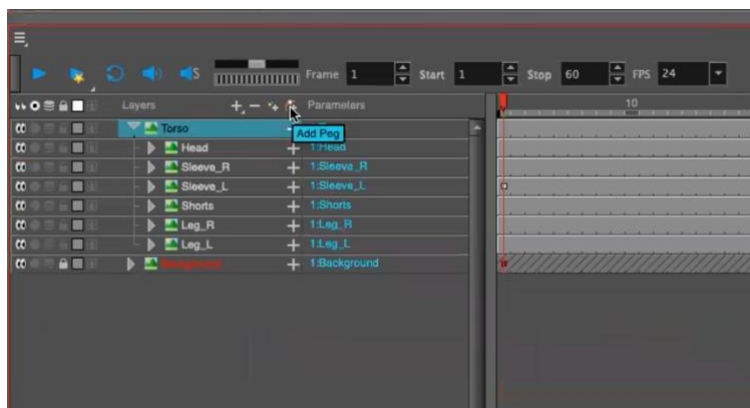


23. Let's fix the way that our character looks in visual space – **Drawing/Image Nodes** hooked into the right of the **Composite Node** will be further back in visual space (think about the multi-plane camera effect) and nodes hooked into the left of the **Composite Node** will be closer to us in visual space.



This will allow you to reorder your character so that it looks the way that it did when it was imported out of Photoshop.

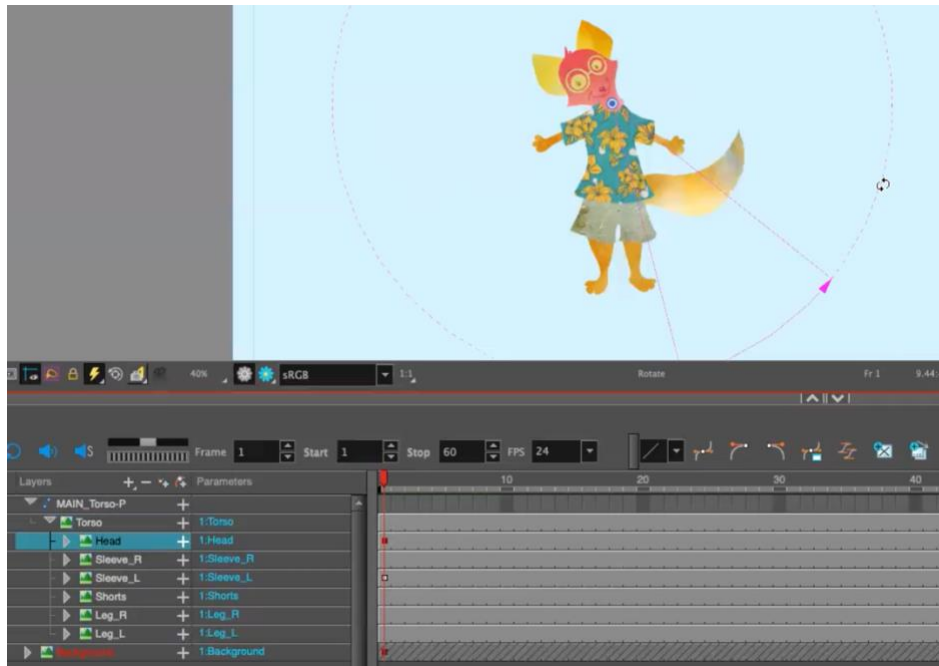
Remember to take your time and have fun – the **Node View** can be overwhelming at first but just like with any new tool that you explore play with it a bit before attempting to do a finalized project. This takes the pressure off so that you can explore without worrying about messing a project up.



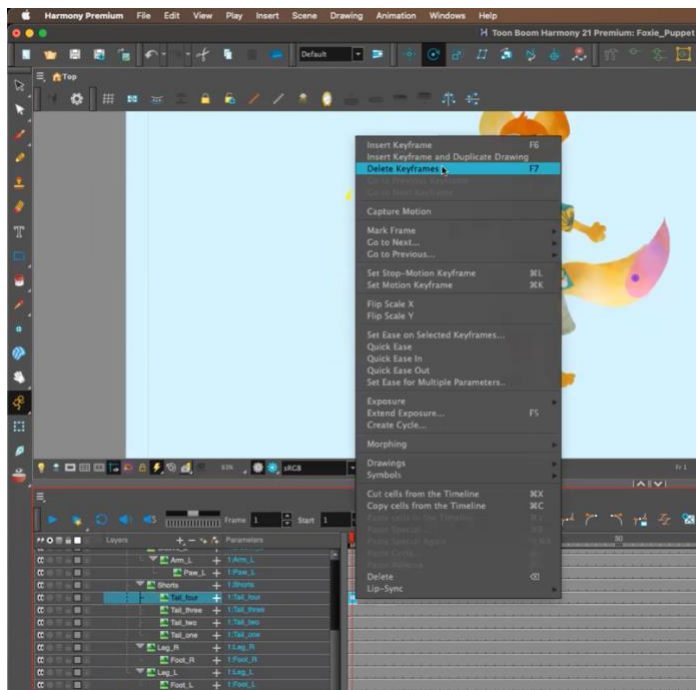
24. In the **Timeline** click on the **Torso** layer and then hover over the symbol to the right and click it to **Add a Peg** – this can be renamed to **MAIN PEG** or **MASTER CONTROL** – or a name of your choosing. Everything will connect and be able to animate on that peg layer when you are ready to animate.

25. Before animation let's move all of the pivot points for each of our parts/layers – you will want to move the pivots to where the joints will rotate – I use the **Rotation Tool** to move and test the pivot points – this tool is darkened in the image below and can be found in the middle of the UI on top of the stage in the default view. Once the **Rotation Tool** is active you can hover over the little blue dot in the middle of the rotation circle – notice that the cursor icon changes to a cross-hair with a **P** next to it – that means that you can now move the pivot anywhere you would like.

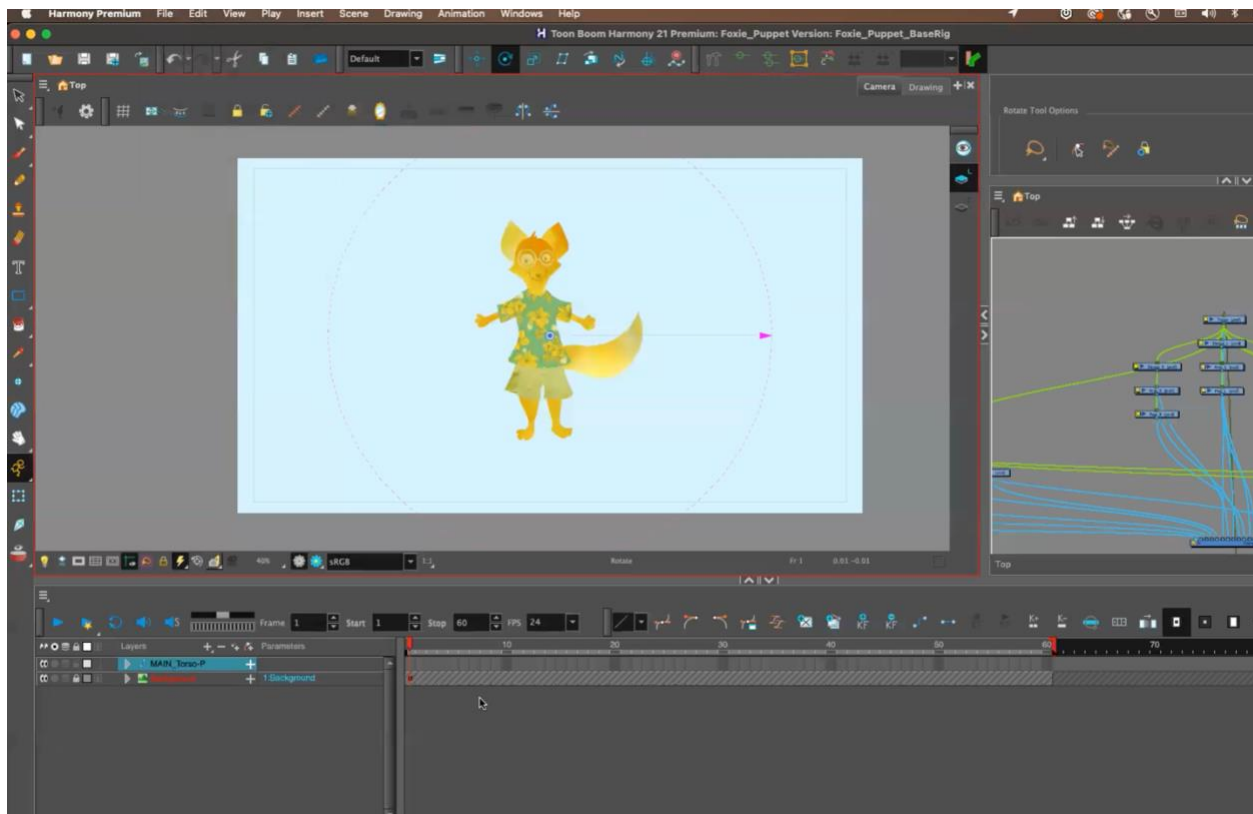




26. Once the pivot is moved you can test the rotation by clicking on the yellow circle that surrounds the layer and move it a bit – this will insert a keyframe (notice the black dot on the Head Layer in the image above) which you can quickly undo with **(Command or Control + Z)**. If you forget to undo the keyframe no worries, you can still delete it later – by right clicking on the keyframe in the timeline and the choose **Delete Keyframe** or hit **F7** (see image below).



27. After all of the pivots have been moved the final step is to make sure all keyframes are deleted to create your base rig file - you always want a file with your rigged character that doesn't have any animation recorded in the timeline so that you can use the character over and over again. Save this file – then do another save (**SAVE AS NEW VERSION**) that you can animate. If you don't like your animation or simply want to start a new animation you can always open the base rig file and save as new version and create your animation. Once your animation is complete – **FILE>EXPORT>MOVIE** to get a compressed movie file that you can share on your website or social media site.



Have fun creating and remember to be positive and productive!
Thank you for taking my course, if you have any questions, please feel free to email me at the address listed at the beginning of this document.